

Then your gut-feeling catches up and you realise that these are fables with new names still struggling with old games. As technology, they are stunning; as attempts to create instant societies, social networks are awesome. Yet the language, the idiom is still a kind of market sociology. As a public domain, social networking is a new fabric of relationships which has still to find its theorists or self reflexivity. These domains lack the insights of sociologists like Jurgen Habermas on the public sphere or Erving Goffman's perspective into impression management or what he called "the presentation of self in public life."

The rituals are different. Earlier you met and chatted; now you just type. Hugs and satire have been replaced by virtual poke and hug-me applications. Not so long ago, in BF (Before Friendster) years, you had the real friendly 'high five' which has been subtly replaced by Hi5. Only time could dictate the character of a friend, now only online quizzes and polls can provide a new tegnum of social character.

The litany of networking begins with numbers. Users of networking sites in India number close to 10 million. But numbers themselves are elusive. About 1-2 million use Indian networking sites like Big Adda, Bharatstudent and vBharat which are basically clones of Western sites. Indian sites are not really Indian as yet. We need to develop an Indian style which derives from the *adda* or a *nukkad* tradition. Samir Passi and Paras Mani, both social networkers, suggest that it should be "more like a *kitli*, less like a *café*". Our Indianness is restricted to marriage sites or to a search for domestic servants as in *Baba job*.

The demography is impressive. The face that Facebook creates is not even a mask. It is a dense curriculum-vitae shaped into the persona one would like to be. It lists the books you like, the music you enjoy, close friends, a notice board of likes and dislikes. It constructs a personality as a billboard. If news is hype about the collective, then the social network hypes or inflates the person, treating every event as happening and every fragment of biography as history. Personally, your visit to Goa might rank in status with the prime minister's visit to the USA.

At one level Facebook has a yellow page of memories. The network becomes a mine-

field of people who you have lost touch with. All one needs is the initiation rite of being tagged or added on as a friend. As you present yourself as a billboard of preferences, old friends, acquaintances discover you, "recognise you" and become add-ons to your life. One of the stunning differences lies in our attitude to photographs.

In *On Photography*, the French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu talked of how photographs in a middle-class album are always still-life affairs. A family album marks ritual events—birth, death, baptism, marriage. It is a systematic serial of rites. Now, the photograph in Facebook explodes into a puff-ball of visuality. Now even videos can be posted, which provide vivid visuality along with acoustic space. It is excessive in display, proliferative in number. Every visit, meeting, encounter becomes a pretext for photography. It is the exhibitionism of the social that redefines Facebook. Samir Passi claims "play, display and replay are its everyday logic".

In challenging what is traditionally social, Facebook or Orkut is desperately keen not to be seen as asocial. It is frenzied in its need for new rituals and mnemonics. Privacy is not opposed to publicity. Privacy is a performance for a select audience. Privacy creates a set of segmented, fragmented publics. More than the PC, what fascinates as an innovation is the mobile. Indians have internalised the idiom of the mobile and reworked its context. They use a sign system of beeps to recode its messages to avoid paying bills, thus creating what has been called strategies of a shoe string through Morse codes of subsistence. What is awesome is that the mobile combines the oral, textual and digital and the acoustic, visual and the virtual. The mobile speaks in several technological dialects. It creates technological entitlements for a whole range of classes. Social networking on the PC seems to suffer from middle class inertia. It is an invention that lacks an improvisation of the social, unlike the mobile that speaks different techno-dialects, empowering a variety of communities. The mobile is the next-generation discovery of the PC, reinvented.

Mobile social networking allows for uploading photos, updating your status, uploading videos and messaging friends from the mobile itself. Instant updates are re-

SOCIAL NETWORKING sites may be faddish, but the phenomenon itself is long-term.

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MARCH 2003 Friendster becomes the first networking site to go live.

AUG 2003 MySpace is created by four eUniverse employees.

JAN 2004 Orkut is launched, followed by Facebook in Feb 2004.



FEB 2005 Three former PayPal employees start YouTube. Google buys it for \$1.65 billion in November 2006.

JULY 2005 Rupert Murdoch buys MySpace for \$580 million.

JULY 2006 Twitter, brainchild of Jack Dorsey, an employee of a podcasting company Odeo, is launched.

OCT 2007 Facebook sells 1.6 per cent stake to Microsoft for \$240 million.

SEPT 2009 Facebook becomes the biggest social networking site with more than 300 million users.